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John Beal

Bassist John Beal is the very definition of a versatile working musician. He has spent seven decades playing onstage and in studios with the likes of Kenny Davern, Harry Belafonte and Leonard Bernstein.

John was interviewed via Zoom on June 18, 2024 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have bassist John Beal with me today. Welcome, sir.

JB: Thanks, Monk.

MR: Congratulations on your lengthy career. I assume you know a fellow named John Wasserman?

JB: Where would I know John Wasserman?

MR: Well because he's a bass player I think, but he wrote this column on the 50 greatest bass players.

JB: Oh yeah, Ron, sure.

MR: Well, and then he did some math. I don't know if you've seen this and I don't know what year this was, but he did some math and he took in account your work with the American Symphony and studio work and Broadway shows etcetera etcetera, and he came up with oh gosh, close to 30,000 gigs for John Beal.

JB: Wow, doesn't he have anything better to do? You know? You can spend the time practicing, that would be good. No, he's the principal bass in the New York City Ballet.

MR: Okay.

JB: I happened to work with his father who was a drummer, one of my first club dates in New York, like a wedding or something. And then I met Ron later at a Wall-to-Wall Bach program at Symphony Space. He sat in with the orchestra. I think he was about 17 or something. So I've known him for a while, but I haven't seen him for a while.

MR: Well when I was looking at your resumes etcetera, this thought came into my head that if you haven't written a book, you should, and I have the title. Are you ready? It goes something like this (it might have to be edited): John Beal, bassist, Baroque to Bach to Bop to Bernstein to Big Band to Broadway, to Big Bird and Belafonte. I couldn't fit in Philip Glass, it didn't have the right ring to it.

JB: That's too long a title. You need a two-word title.

MR: Well if you had to put it into one word, could you put your career into one or two words?

JB: Better than working. Better than working for a living.

MR: Right on. Was there a point when you were young that this career sort of came to be a possibility to you? Did you have what we would now call an epiphany or some like moment that just like put you on this path?

JB: I had encouragement from my first bass teacher, who told me that, "You'll always make a living playing the bass." So that gives you confidence you know, when you hear something like that.

MR: Why? Why the bass?

JB: Because that's what I played and that's my focus you know? And I'm talking junior high school or high school. I guess it was high school you know, and then you know you get hooked as soon as you make a couple of bucks playing something you like you know. I played for a kids' dance class on Saturday nights that made $3 and I barely knew the names of the strings. So that was the beginning you know.

MR: That's one less than I made on my first gig. I made 4.

JB: Right. That's good.

MR: It's a good feeling isn't it, but when I said why did he say that about the bass, do you think the bass is — this was a question for later but I'm going to try it now. Music has changed the way it's produced so much over the years, and I'm wondering if the bass has been somewhat immune from all the changes in technology?

JB: Well it's been affected by pick-ups and, you know the high-tech method of recording to a certain extent. I was just listening to a couple of Chet Baker records recorded in Italy with these bizarre mixes and it sounded like they were just recording the bass through a pick-up that sounded like a banjo you know. But the bass has not changed. I have a bass that's 280 years old, one of my basses, and it's got the same — the sound improves year by year by aging. And a contractor called me up recently about a show that they were doing, "Jelly's Last Jam" and they were very — the director was very interested in having period piano, period drums, and the contractor asked me is there such a thing as a period bass. I said no, they're the same. I mean all basses are a little different because there's no set model but a bass is a bass you know. You look at a modern bass and it looks like an old bass, the same shape except maybe the varnish is showing less wear.

MR: When you came up here in 2005 to play with Kenny — and I recall that you didn't want an amplifier, the room was acoustically really wonderful, but do you find that your fellow musicians on a club date or something play differently volume-wise when you don't have an amplifier? Are they sympathetic to your bass set-up?

JB: It's a great question because I believe that the bass really affects the balance of a band or an orchestra. And one reason I got away from amplifying was because if you use a pick-up and you bow it sounds like a baritone sax you know. So you have to get a full tone

microphone because of the venue or the size of the orchestra. You know the size of the hall you're playing in, the theater. But I really got away from amplified acoustic bass. I went through a whole period where I used a pick-up. Because doing TV shows and live shows, it's just practically necessary if they want to hear the notes you know, because you're not separated acoustically from drums and all the other louder instruments.

MR: Do you recall the first reason you had to play the electric bass?

JB: Yes. Because The Beatles came into existence and at the time I was doing a lot of club dates, weddings and bar mitzvahs and The Beatles hit hard, you know, very popular. And you want to keep getting gigs so I went out and bought a Hagstrom electric bass, took it on the gig you know, faked my way through it. And then I decided that maybe I could convert the acoustic bass so it would sound like an electric bass so I devised a magnetic pick-up and a friend of mine, Dan Armstrong, who is a guitar technician, hooked this thing up. And then pretty soon I realized they wanted to see an electric bass. They don't care about the sound you know. The public wants to see it.

MR: That's really interesting.

JB: That's what started me on the Fender bass you know. And then there was a lot of work because, especially if you could read music on an electric bass. And they used it on recordings because it was so easy to record you know, TV commercials and whatever you know.

MR: How does that work — in the heyday of the studio scene in New York, do you get hooked up with a contractor, establish a reputation and then your phone starts to ring?

JB: It's mostly word of mouth you know, but you do get hooked up with contractors who can depend on what you do because a lot of times they'll book something and the requirements aren't fully known and if you're versatile, and they know you can cover a variety of styles and situations, you know, they want to hire you, you know, so they're covered. And I was lucky enough to be called by several different contractors and I worked for almost everybody. I didn't have any particular affiliation you know.

MR: Did you typically know what you were in for when you showed up at a studio for a date? Did they tell you this is a cigarette commercial or this is a pop recording date for a singer?

JB: No. You'd get called, they give you the time and what instrument. That's it. You know but a record date you'd find out what it is, you'd get a good idea of what to expect. You know like if you're doing an album, if it's a show album or a singer or, you know, whatever.

MR: Who were your favorite drummers — when you walked into the studio and you're hoping to see somebody on drums. Did you have favorites that you worked well with?

JB: Well I liked a lot of drummers. I worked with Ronnie Zito many years on the Tony awards show, and other studio dates. And I played with a lot of great drummers: Gus Johnson, played once with Dannie Richmond, Denzel Best, Morey Feld, George Wettling, Cliff Lehman, Connie Kaye, just, you know Bill LaVorgna another one. I can't even come up with all the names.

MR: Yeah. Ronnie Zito is from up here, from Utica.

JB: I know. So is Jimmy Wormworth.

MR: That's correct.

JB: And Jimmy was, I played a lot with Jimmy when I was at Juilliard. We used to jam a lot. There used to be a lot of jamming going on around town you know, different nights in Harlem, and used to just move around to play. That's my other life.

MR: It seems to me that bassists have a burden to carry that other — especially horn players — don't, and that is someone calls a tune and you are the foundation. You're the harmonic foundation and the time, and if you don't know the tune who are you going to depend on to get through it? So how do you learn tunes, how did you learn the standards so that you were as prepared as possible?

JB: Well I started out listening, playing along with records like one of the first records I played with was Erroll Garner, who had a great beat, right? And you could find the bass notes pretty easily. So your ear gets attuned through fitting in what's going on, and you depend — a lot of times you'll depend on a piano player, but a lot of times the piano player depends on you. I had to play with Duke Ellington's band one time and it was a TV show. And I remember Joe Benjamin had a fender bender and I was on the beach at Fire Island, my daughter was about seven, she ran down to the beach and said, "Hey there's a guy named Mercer on the phone." And so I went in and subbed that night on the TV show, and the point I'm making is Tony Bennett was one of the artists on the show and he wanted to do "I Left My Heart in San Francisco" and Duke was not that familiar with that tune, and he would wait for my bass note and then fill in beautifully you know? So that's an example. You work as a team and you're not independent. If a piano player is going to play a substitution you latch onto it.

MR: In like one beat, right? You latch on within a beat?

JB: Yeah. Or you can sense where they're going you know. Or maybe the first time around they'll play it and then the second eight you'll catch it you know. So you spend your life I say faking through everything.

MR: Yeah, but you can't fake through the American Symphony repertoire and —

JB: Well that's a different bag you know.

MR: So that's sort of my question here. Did you, as a young man, think this thing out as if I'm going to make a living in this business by being able to do absolutely anything? Or did the work just present itself and you learned how to do it as it presented?

JB: That's an embarrassing question you know. When I realized that I wasn't going to be playing with Miles I decided well I'll go to Juilliard — at least I'll be playing the bass, I'll learn how to play in an orchestra and play the instrument, and so that sort of led me into different areas. And I might add that playing "legitimately," in quotes — you know, symphonically — you have different skills and it gives you the longevity in the music business. Like when you're playing in a rhythm section, rhythm sections are stylized according to what's going on in certain time periods. All right? And when they usually look, they go on to the next guy, the next fad or style, and — but if you're playing in a string section there's no end to the need for that ability. You know what I mean? Like Bill LaVorgna, the drummer, I said, — well they'd say, "Get me Bill LaVorgna. Then they'd say, "Get me somebody that sounds like Bill LaVorgna." Then they'd say, "Who's Bill LaVorgna?" You know? So that's longevity you know. But if you play legitimately you'll always be able to work in the string section no matter how — I mean I'm 88 and I'm still doing gigs in orchestras.

MR: What was it about John Beal besides your skill as a player that would keep you high on the contractor's list? Do you have a work ethic you can share with me?

JB: You have to play in tune, you have to play in time, you have to show up on time, and you have to play the right style. There's probably more to it but basically you've got to play in tune, man. You know? If you're in the recording business.

MR: Did you ever have a circumstance where they had to do another take just because of you?

JB: Probably. But a friend who is a bass player and a contractor and he said, "Never confess." A lot of times if you make a mistake it's up to them to hear it. You don't want to confess your mistakes because they might just be going to do another take anyway. And a lot of times they do. So it's just one of those things.

MR: I once asked Bucky Pizzarelli what kind of date might he have done that would be worth coming home and talking to his wife Ruth about — "Hey guess what occurred today." Do you have one of those, like with all the work you do, what is worth bringing up when you get home?

JB: Oh I always comment about what I just did. You know like I played a Dixieland gig Sunday night and I came home and told my wife, "That was like a lot of fun, like I really loved playing that bass. I got the sound that I wanted to get, you know, you don't play with any microphone or amplifier and the place was sold out to a tour of Japanese tourists, older people. And they ended up like really getting into this, dancing and

with pictures, you know put their arms around you. It was really a lot of fun you know. So I just describe that. And I describe my impressions of different jobs. Bucky, Bucky was a great friend of mine from way back and I loved playing with him. In fact we played on a Ruby Braff album, a couple of them. And you know we were just compatible.

MR: That's an interesting concept about — I used to think that almost all veteran jazz people all got along.

JB: I agree.

MR: Yeah. You think that's true then?

JB: I agree, yeah. We're all in the same love situation, you know? We like music. We like jazz. I mean jazz has been my first preference. But I like playing symphonic stuff. I played with Leopold Stokowski and that was a lot of fun. In his last three years in this country, and I was fortunate enough to get principal bass in his orchestra and you'd always end up sweating with him you know, even if you were hung over, you'd go into a rehearsal and in about a half hour you're sweating you know. He really made you play.

MR: Do you think modern classical music is — I'm not sure where "modern" starts but — more difficult to play than the classics, the Romantic period and Baroque music? That's a wide question but I once had an experience playing a Honegger piece and there was a saxophone part and man I could not keep track of where it was. It was so harmonically dense and of course they had 60 bars of rest before I came in and talk about sweating. Please give me a cue.

JB: Yeah. Well you know you're getting into a controversial area you know. There was a book called — now I can't remember, damn — *The Agony of Modern Music* by Henry Pleasants. And he said the real modern music is jazz, because like from Stravinsky on you know it got so complicated with different time signatures and it's like a made-up idiom sort of because the complexity of playing contemporary music, it's like you don't know what style — I mean you have to learn the style of each individual composer but it's like — you know — complicated. It's a specific skill you have to — I don't want to —

MR: It seems like the music composition in the classical world keeps trying to do something new and I think it might have to do with getting a grant — getting grants to write new work and how far can you go and still do something new? And what we get is what maybe you're struggling to find in your description.

JB: Well I have my own opinion about some of that stuff but you know a lot of guys specialize in it and they're happy doing that. I have an example, there was a series called "Music From Japan" and they used to display the scores in the lobby, you know, under glass. And Henry Pleasants, in this book he mentions like composers, they have to get a

teaching job so they can explain their music you know. They've got to explain the music, man.

MR: You didn't have to explain that Dixieland music, did you?

JB: No. No, not to the Japanese people. The funny thing is the host of this thing the other night was saying — the leader asked her to translate what he was saying. And he said, "We're going to play a tune from a place in Chicago called the Royal Garden, it's the 'Royal Garden Blues.'" And so she said, "They're going to play 'Royal Garden Brews." So it's like about beer, you know?

MR: Lost in translation. So you were a young man with, when you went with Woody Herman.

JB: Yeah.

MR: I wondered, let's see, mid-'50s?

JB: '55 I got the gig, yeah. I was there for about a year and then they broke the band up.

MR: Were you sorry the band broke up? Were you enjoying it?

JB: Oh yeah. Yeah. It was great. Yeah I really enjoyed it. Nat Pierce was there, Richie Kamuka, you know, it was a lot of fun. Mostly one-nighters for a year. I think I was 19 when I got in that band.

MR: That's good. That's a young man's game doing that.

JB: Yeah. And I still play on the same instrument. I have played on different instruments but I've been playing that bass for 70 years. And it's the best it's ever sounded right now.

MR: How did the band get around at that time? Did you have a luxurious bus?

JB: Well no, it was cars and we got paid an extra $25 for driving. And then there was a couple of wrecks you know and then they got a bus. And it was a kind of broken down bus. To go in reverse the driver had to go out and stick a broom handle into the transmission. I remember we played at Newport Jazz Festival once and the bus had broken down so they had to get a school bus, and we showed up at Newport in a school bus.

MR: "Ladies and Gentlemen, The Woody Herman Orchestra here they come in the yellow bus."

JB: Yeah. But it was a swinging band you know, it was a lot of fun.

MR: Can you define swing? What a question, ey?

JB: Can I define swing? Swing is when everything is clicking and it's intense and it feels good. What can I say? Everybody's on the same plane.

MR: Exactly. And I think it has something to do as well as like the volume balance between the rhythm section instruments 'cause when you think about Basie's classic rhythm section it sounded like one instrument almost, everything is just so in sync.

JB: Yeah, it's all about the beat, man. And all music is about the beat. And a conductor that has the beat is usually a good conductor you know. And he doesn't even have to read music, if he's got the beat he can survive. I've worked with conductors like that.

MR: Wow. You mean that they didn't really — weren't reading the score?

JB: Right. The ear you know. And the ear determines pitch too you know, it's not just pressing the buttons you know. You adjust. But the beat is primary.

MR: Did you have a moment in a studio date where you started to see the technology enter the picture, either with replacing people or different ways of, you know, overdubbing and all that. Do you recall when that started to creep into the scene?

JB: Yeah. When I started there was not so much tracking you know, multiple tracking, so you had to play it right the first time you know, or every time. And then when the multiple tracking came in and punching in tracks like — guys wouldn't have the pressure to play correctly the first time. You know what I mean? 'Cause they knew that they could re-do a mistake. That had an influence I believe. And also when the mix ended up being with the engineer — like I remember with Woody's band we played in Madison, Wisconsin and a doctor had a stereo Ampex machine and he wanted to record the band. He had two mics — Telefunken — and put one in front of the band and one in front of the rhythm section. And that was like a natural balance. Now when the multiple track recording came in they mix it later — to the taste of the engineer you know. And I noticed sometimes an engineer will not even come out and listen to the sound in the studio, the natural sound of the bass, and it became very technical you know.

MR: That's a very interesting take on the effect on the musicians being less demanding about their own performance.

JB: Right. Well you know it became more specialized. A guy can go in and try something ten times if he has to you know.

MR: Yes, and then of course the engineer and the producer can take those ten tracks and they can create a new one. That's a favorite thing, you know, like take a piece — the first four bars from this one —

JB: Yeah. I hear it on records. This one record I played on it with Gene Roland arrangements, it was Jimmy Knepper's album and Al and Zoot were on it and Clark Terry, Snooky Young. And swinging. Called "Swinging Friends" was the name of the record. And sometimes — well in particular the last chorus like a totally different tempo because of a splice, you know a bad splice, because of an ensemble problem you know. Maybe it wasn't clean so they just like spliced in the last chorus in a totally different tempo from another take. You know, and you can hear it a lot of times on records. A friend of mine who played in the Los Angeles Philharmonic said this one conductor I won't name was

could tell that he learned the piece from a recording that had a mistake in it. You know. Bad splice.

MR: Interesting. Years ago I was able to sit in the orchestra pit of a production of "Cats" and I was watching, this was like a touring group, and I was watching the guys on the synthesizers, and they'd play their part and then they'd pick up a magazine, you know, and they would read, and then they'd put the magazine down and play their part. And I started to wonder, when you play a Broadway show for a length of time, sometimes years, how do you keep your focus? How do you not zone out and miss your cue?

JB: Well you're on automatic pilot you know. I mean it's Broadway, you're repeating eight shows a week if you do eight shows. But like I played "Phantom of the Opera" for 11-1/2 years but the contract on Broadway in New York you may send a sub for 50% of the shows. So I was able to work normal freelance stuff as well as the show. But you know where you are in the show. Some people would memorize their parts. I've never been able to separate that process, I always would read the part. But you know it depends on the quality of musicians in the result of the performance and I feel that that 50% rule made much better orchestras on Broadway because you'd get better players that are doing other things. And before that you'd be at the mercy of the conductor or contractor if you wanted to take off you know, they didn't have to let you off so they'd get guys that the only thing they did was the show, grind it out you know.

MR: Was that a musicians' union negotiation? To get that 50% subbing bit in there?

JB: I don't know how that happened but it was a great thing. I know one conductor that I worked for, Paul Gemignani, he always hired a band because he wanted who he wanted. He wanted good players and he just said, "Well just take care of the chair, you know, make sure it's covered if you want to take off." So that was like really the beginning of that concept, and I was amazed when they actually put it in the contract you know.

MR: So you —

JB: And then later on certain conductors wanted to tighten it up and make it less liberal.

MR: I see. But you must have a list then of possible subs: first person I call, second person I call.

JB: Well you just want to get somebody that can cover it, you know, take care of business. And I got a letter from one contractor, he says, "I don't care how many times you take off but you've got to reduce the number of subs on the list from 18" — I had 18 different subs, and the letter of the contract says you can have five. But there's always a loophole you know you can take one off the list and put somebody else on and you know, like that. I haven't been involved in that too much lately so — but now it's pretty — you know Broadway is the most desirable field of work in New York. It's the best paying jobs

MR: If you had — I'm going to ask you think back — in 1974 I'm going back from 2024 — what kind of advice might you have given to someone coming up as opposed to the advice you would give them now? Can we talk about what you would have said to a 19-year-old musician in 1974 trying to find a place in the business?

JB: I guess just play — I'll quote Mose Allison, he said, "Play every chance you get — play every chance you get." Now there's not as many opportunities. There's plenty of musicians around but the opportunities are limited. All those gigs, you know, don't pay very much. It's hard to make a living at this time.

MR: It's frustrating to think why has this occurred. I guess there's a number of reasons why some of those gigs have gone away: DJs etcetera.

JB: Yeah. Yeah I mean I made a living playing club dates for seven years when I first got married, and now they don't have the same — there's no market. It's mostly DJs I think doing that kind of work. There are some bands working at that but I don't know, I've been away from that for so long. But it was — and I must say that doing that kind of work you really learn a lot you know, you learn how to fake through tunes and, you know, they used to have bands that faked everything, you know pretty big sized, like a sax section faking harmonies and you know pretty skillful players.

MR: Oh yeah I've heard about that, like the band leader would say "Misty" and hold up three fingers or whatever, and then as "Misty" would come to an end they'd call another tune, two flats.

JB: Oh yeah. The hand signals, sure. And the guys would fake harmonies and you know there was a certain pool of musicians who were excellent at that.

MR: Yeah. I'm going to run a few names by you and see if you have any recollections or comments about them. I'm going to start with Nina Simone?

JB: Nina Simone, my comment is that I was with Woody's band in Atlantic City playing at the Steel Pier and we had a night off, and I went into a bar and there was this woman playing and singing and it sounded great. And I asked the bartender, "Who is that?" He said, "Nina Simone but her real name is Eunice Brown." And I went up there to speak with her and I said, "Eunice" and she said, "Who told you that?" And she was using Nina. And then many years later I got to play on her record that she wrote, you know, in the string section of a record called "Baltimore." Dave Matthews did the charts to that, good string section. And I was friends with Al Schackman who was her M.D. and I played with him in other situations.

MR: How about Philip Glass?

JB: Philip Glass was in Juilliard when I was there and he liked to jam. He had a house in Chinatown that he paid $65 a month rent. It was like a pretty, frame house, ramshackle,

bass on a motorcycle and we would play down there. And then later on you know what happened with him, he got very big. I played a couple of film scores with him, played some incidental music for a Beckett play that he wrote for tympani and double bass. And Beckett had instructed that there be no music for this play, I forget the name of the play. So he wrote tympani and bass. I guess that's not music. But talking about technology and recording you know, his style is repetitive phrases, repetitive with slight variations. So recording is like really tough and you have to go back and punch in and the repetitions — it was very hard to keep track of that stuff you know.

MR: Yeah. Okay, play this measure 80 times.

JB: Well not 80, but maybe four bars four times and then eight bars six times, you know, with like slight differences you know. But you know, a very popular style.

MR: I was watching a video of his music — I can't pronounce this, "Koyaanisqatsi." I think you might have played on that. Sound familiar?

JB: No.

MR: Oh okay.

JB: Sorry.

MR: That's all right. I think it's pretty standard with you fellows to say, "Oh you played on that, don't you remember?" I remember Bucky did that a number of times.

JB: You remember some things but I swear to God like some commercials, you know jingles, you go in for one hour and you don't even remember what it was, and you get residual checks for years. You know thousands of dollars perhaps. And you don't even remember what the product was. It's funny.

MR: And is the reverse of that true? Have you ever — do you and Cynthia try to keep track of things like what happened with that Paul Simon date, did I ever get paid for that? Or don't you have to do that?

JB: Well you know you keep track of when you — you're sure when you don't get paid. You keep track of that. But like you know when you're doing a lot of jingles, every 13 weeks is a payment if they keep running it. So ads would add up. And the great thing about it was the pension contributions of 10% on residuals as well as the actual date. So that's a great feature, you know, thanks to the union.

MR: Can you name a commercial that for one reason or another stuck in your head that you played on?

JB: Well a lot of early McDonald's commercials and like "Nationwide is on your side," "Aren't you glad you use Dial," a lot of orchestra stuff that you don't remember particularly. But it's fun to do them, you know you go in, do it fast and — because they don't want to go overtime, you know it's just an hour. And we were doing a public

domain commercial with Rossini opera, you know a 30-second jingle and so somebody would say, "That's a great length for an opera — 30 seconds."

MR: I'm going to use that, John. How about do you remember playing on "Jamaica Farewell"?

JB: What's that, Belafonte?

MR: Yeah. Yeah. Belafonte.

JB: I remember doing a recording with him.

MR: Well I'm not sure how much I should trust all this but what about playing for Big Bird?

JB: Yeah you know it's funny you say that because I went to school, I took some college in Washington DC, my hometown, and Jerry Nelson was in the same class, and he was Big Bird. He ended up being Big Bird. So, small world you know. And he also lived in my neighborhood in New York. I ran into him. But I don't remember the music. I remember one thing on the Muppet Movie, the arranger — eh, 88 years old, my memory — but Kermit the Frog was doing a jazz waltz and the bass player, the electric bass player had just gotten a new bass, a six string bass. And so he was improvising a bass part and he started playing on the low string you know, he had low Bs and it sounded like Wagner, you know, but this was like a frog singing a little light jazz waltz. It was funny.

MR: I always wanted to work on the Muppet show, I thought that was just brilliant throughout.

JB: Yeah the guys in that band, it was a really nice job.

MR: I think there was Bob Cranshaw on a lot of that.

JB: Yeah Cranshaw was the gig, yeah. That was his gig. I subbed for Cranshaw with Jimmy Rowles a lot too, down at Bradley's. That was a lot of fun.

MR: He's very respected.

JB: Bob is great. Yeah. Great guy.

MR: Here's a question about, over the years I'm sure you've played with people in different situations who were not readers, who were self-taught, often times guitar players. I wonder if you almost surprisingly learned anything from those self-taught musicians?

JB: Well the first one I learned from was Erroll Garner on his records. He was self-taught. He couldn't read music. And years later Woody Herman made a record, a duet record with him and we were playing at Basin Street and they were promoting that record and they invited Erroll to come and play with the band, you know it was like a three-tune medley that modulated. And he sat in and played. He couldn't read the chart at all, but he just played it by ear you know. So as far as people who couldn't read, how about a guy like Eddie Diehl, the guitar player? Great player. I don't think he could read. You know I mean reading is overrated.

MR: I concur. And I've learned from some of the guitar players especially that their ears are so tuned in because they learned that way, and they sometimes think of things

patterns etcetera. They're not concerned with that, they're concerned with if it sounds good then it is good.

JB: Yeah. I mean I'll go along with that. Yeah I mean sometimes I'll play with a younger player that might not know a tune, he goes on his phone and looks it up and he's playing from his phone. And it's like I don't get it, you know. Like for instance, like Mingus, you know the way he'd rehearse a band, they didn't have music, they'd make up — you know he'd sing the parts or he'd rehearse, he'd develop it without music you know. And you could do that with a small group.

MR: This is almost an aside but I watched an interview with you, I think it was fairly recent, it was another young man there, and somehow this bit about fixed Do and movable Do came up. And I have to say I'd never heard of such a thing until my own daughter brought it up, who is a music teacher, and it was something about Eastman School of Music. And I said, "What are you talking about?"

JB: Well oh Christ — it's solfeggio you know it's like fixed Do would be C is do. And so Do Re Me Fa So La Ti Do in the key of C. But movable it would be Do would be the fundamental of the key you're in, like A flat would be Do. So I don't know, I was never good at — as Jonathan Tunick, this classmate of mine, used to say I used to put on my shades and read the *New York Post* in solfeggio class, which I don't remember. But you know conductors like — there was a conductor at Juilliard, Jean Morel, great conductor but very French and disciplined. And he used solfeggio and he would sing something in fixed Do. One time Shostakovich was visiting orchestra rehearsal and I don't know if that was — but anyhow some bigwigs were at the rehearsal and he was trying to explain how the flute part and the pick-up to a certain letter, letter Q, and the note was F, Fa. And he would say, he'd say, "Fa-Q" in other words the pick-up was to the letter Q. He'd say, "Fa- Q" in front of all these people. It was funny man.

MR: Oh you can't make those things up.

JB: No I didn't make it up, man, it happened.

MR: Yeah, that's great. That's like a Bill Crow story. How about Leonard Bernstein?

JB: How about him?

MR: How about him?

JB: Really he had the beat man. He had a great pulse. And he didn't have to convey it, it was just there you know. It was there. And I played a couple of things with him. I played on a mass that he wrote, a recording, I played actually Fender bass on that. And there was a ballet piece he wrote called "Dybbuk" that I played on. And we did "Symphony of Psalms" at Carnegie Hall one time that he conducted. Really memorable, to me.

MR: What kind of date or event tends to make you anxious or nervous? Is there anything that

JB: Well you're always apprehensive playing a symphony concert, especially if you don't trust the conductor. You know? That makes you apprehensive.

MR: What wouldn't you trust about a conductor? For cues or is it more than that?

JB: No. I know one conductor who gives you a cue after you play, but —

MR: In other words he heard it and goes, "Oh yes, thank you for coming in."

JB: I mean that's being a little facetious you know but what I wouldn't trust about a conductor is that the conductor doesn't have the beat man, if he doesn't have a good beat you know it's a thing you have to — show a difference. A lot of orchestras are able to do that. They play together, you know, self-preservation. And mentioning Broadway, some of these conductors were rehearsal piano players and they learn the music and they get to conduct it and you know you shouldn't follow them. And if a sub comes in and follows him he's wrong because he's not with the band, because the band knows better than to follow the conductor. I don't want to get negative man.

MR: Yeah. I understand what you're saying. I've also, along the technology lines I've heard drummers talk about playing a Broadway show from another room.

JB: Oh yeah. Yeah my friend Warren Odze, he was in another room, he was playing "Shrek." You don't even know who you're playing with. And if you don't have the mix in your phones you could be way off because you're looking at the conductor. I had that happen to me.

MR: It's sort of like that thing we can do this but should we. So last question, John, when did you know that you had the beat? Because you've talked about the beat a lot today and was it something you think you were born with or was it early exposure with records?

JB: The beat is an opinion. It's an opinion, where you put it. And you try to adjust to what's happening if you have to, but you have to stand your ground to a certain extent you know what I mean? It's like it's not infallible. So I don't know I just try to keep time you know and try not to drag or rush. You know what Al Cohn said — no Carl Fontana said to Al Cohn, "I played with this drummer last night, every time we played with sticks he rushed and every time he played with brushes he'd drag." And Al says, "Well couldn't he play with one of each?" I like that one.

MR: I do too. Drummers, some drummers like to play with the time more than others. Not play the time, play with the time. And if you're with somebody like that do you like dig in and say all right if you have to play with the time then I'm going to play the time for you to mess with?

JB: Well what do you mean playing with the time? You mean like move it around?

MR: Yeah, moving it —

JB: Why would they do that?

MR: Because I think it's the progression of the instrument or what — maybe it goes under the big umbrella of freedom. I don't want to be tied to just being a timekeeper, I want to be experimental, I want to express myself.

JB: Well then you have to conform to that. I mean if that's what you're going for you have to go for that. You have to go for whatever it is you know. You always have to go for it, not just be rigid you know. That's why you change styles and you try to get the best result from what you're going for. That's all.

MR: All right well that's a good way to wrap this up. What's your next gig? You had a Dixieland thing, what's the next thing for you?

JB: Well I just got a call, I mean an email for this job, it's in Madison Square Garden. It's three concerts with the American Symphony, and let's see if I could — Joe Hisaishi Music from the Studio Ghibli Films. It's anime. And this guy is a composer and conductor and pianist. Very good. And it's a lot of fun to do. I did one a few years ago in Carnegie Hall. And this is three concerts at Madison Square Garden in July, what is it, the 11th, 12th and 13th. And that's like 16,000 people in that place. And so we'll be honking it out there, you know. I mean it's good music, it really is fun. Last time I played there was with The Who. I played there in Jones Beach, got a chance to play with The Who. That was great.

MR: How do they amplify — were you playing upright bass?

JB: Yeah, oh yeah.

MR: How do they amplify it for some venue like that?

JB: Well that one they put a pick-up on the bass which I wasn't happy about but this particular one they'll use microphones. The microphone gets more or less accurate sound, you know I mean let's face it, recordings — I want to say that all Duke Ellington's recordings you can really hear the bass on every one going all the way back. You know? He made sure the bass was not buried.

MR: I remember a story from Norman Simmons talking about hearing Duke's music and the bass coming through those big Zenith speakers and he went like this, and it obviously made an impression on him.

JB: Yeah. Well I'm trying to remember — the bass player with Brubeck, Eugene Wright.

MR: Eugene Wright.

JB: I saw an interview with him and he said when he was 13 years old he went to hear Basie's band and he could hear Walter Page, he would be up in the balcony and he could hear Walter Page cut through the band. You know? And you know that says a lot that the acoustic bass could be heard.

MR: And there's a percussiveness to it that I think serves well when you're in a trio like,

JB: Yeah I don't get to play with too many drummers anymore. You know I play a lot of sessions with guitar players and horn players. And I've been using gut strings the last few years. I started on gut and I'm ending up on gut, having a second childhood, you know, really into it.

MR: Well you've come a long way since the $3 dance class gigs.

JB: Yeah. Now I'm doing $50 Dixieland gigs.

MR: But you're still having a blast.

JB: Yeah, I must say.

MR: All right. Thanks a lot, John. It's a pleasure hooking up with you again and I hope to see you in person at some point.

JB: Yeah maybe, you never know.

MR: You never know.

JB: You know I think I have a DVD of us in Hamilton College, you sat in on clarinet?

MR: Soprano sax.

JB: Soprano, yeah. I never had a player so I never saw it.

MR: Okay.

JB: I remember the gig you know. Tony DeNicola, James Chirillo.

MR: And Kenny. Kenny was one of a kind.

JB: I'll say. I miss him. We miss him. A lot of people miss Kenny. Yeah. All right man.

MR: All right. Thank you very much.

JB: You're welcome.